La Invasión

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The war the United States remembers as destiny, Mexico remembers as something very different: la intervención norteamericana — the North American invasion that marched on its capital and took half its land. This is the same war, from the other side of the river.

One war, seen from the south

You have read how the United States told this war — as the fulfillment of a national destiny. Now cross the border, and the same war becomes almost unrecognizable.

To Mexico, this was not destiny. It was la invasión — a stronger neighbor marching an army onto Mexican soil, bombarding Mexican cities, raising its flag over the Mexican capital, and walking away with half the country. The map above is the wound. Every shaded mile was Mexico in 1845.

"Results of the Mexican War, 1848" — the dark band marks the Mexican Cession: roughly half of Mexico's national territory, lost to the United States. Map, public domain (Library of Congress).

Mexico in the 1840s

Mexico had won its independence from Spain only in 1821 — barely twenty years before the war. It was enormous on the map, stretching from Central America to what is now Oregon, but it was young, poor, and deeply unstable, with governments that rose and fell again and again.

Its far north — Alta California, New Mexico, Texas — was vast, thinly settled, and hard to govern from a capital thousands of miles away. A confident, fast-growing United States looked at that same land and saw an empty frontier waiting to be taken. Mexicans saw their national territory.

A nation at war with itself

Even as the invasion came, Mexico could not stop fighting itself. Power swung violently between Santa Anna and liberal reformers like Valentín Gómez Farías; governments were made and unmade; the church, the army, and rival factions all pulled in different directions.

A country that had changed leaders a dozen times in twenty years now had to face a united, confident invader. Mexican soldiers often marched unpaid and unsupplied while politicians quarreled in the capital. The war was lost partly on the battlefield — and partly in the chaos behind the lines.

Antonio López de Santa Anna — soldier, president, exile, and president again, many times over. Portrait, oil, public domain (source to confirm).

Texas

The trouble began with Texas. American settlers invited into the Mexican state of Coahuila y Tejas grew to outnumber Mexicans there, and in 1836 they broke away and declared an independent republic. Mexico never recognized it. To Mexico City, Texas was a rebellious province stolen with the quiet backing of the United States.

So when the United States annexed Texas as a state in 1845, Mexico saw it exactly as the United States would have seen a foreign power annexing one of its states in revolt: as an act of aggression. Mexico broke off relations. The two countries were now one spark from war.

The war the Americans started

President Polk ordered American troops south of the Nueces River, into a strip of land Mexico had always considered its own, all the way to the Río Bravo (the Rio Grande). From Mexico's point of view, a foreign army had crossed into Mexican territory and built a fort pointed at the town of Matamoros.

When Mexican cavalry attacked that army, Polk told Congress that Mexico had "shed American blood upon the American soil." But to Mexicans, the blood had been shed on Mexican soil, by soldiers defending their own country from an invasion. The same skirmish starts a 'defensive' war for one nation and an 'unprovoked' one for the other.

General Antonio López de Santa Anna, president and commander of Mexico's armies — a brilliant, disastrous, endlessly returning figure in Mexican history. Lithograph, 1847, public domain (Library of Congress).

An outmatched army

Mexico fought, and often fought bravely, but it was overmatched from the start. Its armies were large but poorly supplied, racked by the same political chaos that toppled its governments; its soldiers were frequently unpaid conscripts led by feuding generals.

At Buena Vista, Santa Anna threw a huge army at Zachary Taylor and nearly won — then withdrew, exhausted and out of supplies. American printmakers turned that retreat into the triumphant scene above. Notice who makes the picture, and who is shown fleeing: even the images of this war were mostly made by the winners.

"Flight of the Mexican Army at the Battle of Buena Vista," February 1847 — a U.S. print celebrating the Mexican retreat. Lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

The bombardment of Veracruz

Then came the invasion by sea. General Winfield Scott landed thousands of troops near Veracruz and laid siege to the walled port. For days American guns shelled the city — and the shells did not fall only on soldiers.

Hundreds of civilians — men, women, and children — were killed in the bombardment. Even some American and European observers were sickened by it. In the American telling, Veracruz is the clever opening move of a brilliant campaign. In the Mexican telling, it is the day a foreign navy rained fire on a Mexican city full of families.

"Scene in Vera Cruz during the Bombardment," March 1847 — shells fall among civilians in the streets of the port city. Lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

“A sus habitantes”

Here is a rare thing in the record of this war: a Mexican voice, printed in Mexico, speaking to Mexicans. As Scott’s army pushed inland, the state congress of Puebla printed this broadside begging its people to stop fighting one another and turn to the real enemy.

It names two threats at once: the invading “huestes del Norte” — the hosts of the North — and the “fatal división” tearing the republic apart from within. Read it and you hear a nation in crisis trying to rally itself even as the capital’s fall drew near. Almost every picture of this war was made by the winners; this is a page in the invaded nation’s own words.

The Congress of the State of Puebla addresses its people, 18 March 1847 — pleading with them to set aside their divisions and face the invasion. Broadside, public domain (source to confirm).

Chapultepec and Los Niños Héroes

Scott fought his way to the gates of the capital. The last great obstacle was Chapultepec, the castle on a hill that held Mexico’s national military academy. American troops stormed it on 13 September 1847.

Among the defenders were teenage cadets — the Niños Héroes, the “Boy Heroes.” Mexican memory holds that six of them refused to retreat, and that the last, rather than let the flag be captured, wrapped himself in it and leaped from the walls. Historians debate the details. But as a story, it became one of the most powerful in the nation — proof that even in defeat, Mexico’s children would not surrender their country.

“Storming of the Fortress of Chapultepec,” 13 September 1847 — the castle guarding Mexico City, which housed the national military academy. Lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

The flag over the Palacio

The next day, American forces marched into the center of Mexico City and raised the United States flag over the National Palace — the heart of the nation. For the United States, this was the triumphant climax that gave the Marines “the halls of Montezuma.”

For Mexico, it was the lowest moment in its young history: a foreign army occupying the capital, the government in flight, the country at the mercy of the invader’s terms. There was almost nothing left to do but negotiate how much would be lost.

Half a nation, signed away

The Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo (1848) ended the war. Mexico gave up roughly half its national territory — all of California, Nevada, and Utah, and much of Arizona, New Mexico, Colorado, and Wyoming — and accepted the Rio Grande as the Texas border. In return it received $15 million, a sum many Mexicans saw as an insult: payment for land taken at gunpoint.

Overnight, tens of thousands of Mexicans found themselves living inside the United States, their homeland redrawn around them. The treaty promised to protect their property and rights. In the decades that followed, many lost both anyway.

“United States at the Beginning of the Mexican War, 1846” — the pale yellow ‘Republic of Mexico’ shows how much of the continent was Mexican before the war. Map, public domain (Library of Congress).

The wound that did not close

The United States remembers this war, when it remembers it at all, as a short and successful one. Mexico has never had that luxury. La intervención norteamericana is taught as a national trauma — the moment a young country was invaded by its neighbor and lost half of itself.

The memory lives in monuments like the one to the Niños Héroes, in street names and holidays, and in song — the corridos and ballads that kept the grief and the defiance alive. A defeated nation cannot celebrate a victory, so it does something harder: it remembers, and it refuses to forget who did the taking.

Fresh graves from the war — one of the earliest photographs ever made of an American war’s dead. Daguerreotype, c. 1847, public domain (source to confirm).

One event, two nations, two truths

You have now read this war from both sides. The American telling and the Mexican telling do not merely emphasize different things — they often describe the same moment in opposite words. A “grand entry” is an “occupation.” A “defensive war” is “la invasión.” A “destiny” is a “theft.”

That is the heart of point of view. Both sides use real facts; both leave things out; both have reasons to tell it their way. Your job as a historian is not to pick the side you like — it is to understand why each one sees what it sees, and then to judge the evidence for yourself.